German Political Talk Show Guests, 2008–2026

Codebook

Nicolas Wesseler
nicolas-wesseler.net

`talkshow_guests.csv` has one row for every guest in every episode of six German talk shows: Markus Lanz, Maybrit Illner, Maischberger, Anne Will, hart aber fair and Caren Miosga. It has 13,747 rows: 3,096 episodes, broadcast between 11 June 2008 and 13 October 2026, with 4,216 different guests.

How to cite

If you use this data, please cite it as:

> Wesseler, Nicolas (2026). German Political Talk Show Guests, 2008--2026 [Data set]. https://nicolas-wesseler.net/#data

BibTeX:

```
@misc{wesseler2026talkshows,
   author = {Wesseler, Nicolas},
   title = {German Political Talk Show Guests, 2008--2026},
   year = {2026},
   howpublished = {\url{https://nicolas-wesseler.net/#data}}
}
```

Variables

Variable	Meaning	Empty
`show`	Name of the show.	0%
`date`	Broadcast date (YYYY-MM-DD).	0%
`episode_title`	Title of the episode (in German). Markus Lanz episodes have no topic title; they are called "Folge 1369" or "Sendung vom 14.09.2023".	0%
`episode_url`	Link to the episode page on fernsehserien.de.	0%
`guest_name`	Name of the guest.	0%
`guest_role`	Who the guest is, as listed for this episode (in German), e.g. "Ökonom" or "Bundesgesundheitsminister".	1.7%

Variable	Meaning	Empty
`party`	Party of the guest, for politicians of CDU, CSU, SPD, Grüne, FDP, Linke, AfD, BSW and Freie Wähler. Empty for everyone else, including non-politicians.	69.3%
`gender`	`female` or `male`. Not reported by anyone: derived from the guest's job title (e.g. "Ökonomin") or first name, so it can be wrong. Empty if it could not be derived.	4.0%
`main_theme`	Main topic of the episode, one of the 21 topics listed below.	0%
`theme_2`	Second topic of the episode, if there is one.	4.0%
`theme_3`	Third topic of the episode, if there is one.	17.6%
`theme_4`	Fourth topic of the episode, if there is one.	53.9%
`birth_year`	Year of birth, from Wikidata. Only available for politicians.	69.9%
`birth_state`	German state of birth, from Wikidata. Only available for politicians born in Germany.	71.2%

The topic columns were assigned by an AI model (Claude Opus 5.5) that read the episode description. The topics are listed in order of importance.

The 21 topics: Covid-19; Ukraine war & Russia; Middle East conflicts; International politics & USA; Migration & refugees; Climate & energy; Economy & finance; Social policy, pensions & labour; German domestic politics & elections; Far right & extremism; Security, terror & military; Crime, justice & law; Health & medicine (not Covid); Science & technology; Religion & ethics; Personal stories & fate; Society, family & education; Culture, film & music; Media & celebrity; Sports; Other.

Which years can be used

Guest lists exist only for part of the episodes, and the file contains only episodes that have one. For other years, most episodes are missing.

Show	Years
Markus Lanz	2013–2026
Maybrit Illner	2014–2026
Maischberger	2015–2023 (almost no guest lists from 2024)
Anne Will	2016–2023 (the show ended in 2023)
Hart aber fair	2015–2026
Caren Miosga	2024–2026 (the show started in 2024)

Source

Episodes and guests: the episode guides (Episodenguide) of fernsehserien.de, one per show: Markus Lanz, Maybrit Illner, Maischberger, Anne Will, hart aber fair and Caren Miosga. Date, title and description of each episode, and the guest names and roles that are listed in the description, were extracted from the pages as saved on 14 October 2026.

Party, birth year and birth state: Wikidata (CC0), queried on 14–15 October 2026, and the guest lists.

Topics: assigned with an AI model (Claude Opus 5.5) from the episode descriptions.

Gender: derived from job titles and first names.